

Pioneer Junior College

GP Bulletin 2018

Issue 1



The world is your textbook

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Section A: The student essays in this section are graded B.

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Section B: The student essays in this section are graded A

The objectives of the essays in this section are to illustrate how the various components of essay writing are largely and/or sufficiently addressed.

Minor mistakes of each essay (if any) are explained in the margins, and learning points summed up at the end of each essay.

Page 23 'Whoever controls the media controls the world.' To what extent do you agree?

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Can war be avoided when countries continue to invest in weapons?

STEP 2: Analyse the Question Requirements (QTK)

Q => Can or cannot be avoided. Distinction between degrees of ability for greater evaluation

T => The ability to avoid war given that countries are investing in weapons

K => Weapons, avoided = prevented, the assumption that investment in weapons causally necessitates wars or heightens its probability, weapons could refer to ammunition, artillery or nuclear warheads and Inter-Continental Ballistic Missiles (ICBM)
Continue = a trend that persists, which perhaps strengthens the assumption that war is never far from the horizon *as long as* weapons are being invested in
Invest = monetarily, possibly apportioning a sizeable portion of the country's revenue or budget in the purchase of, if not necessarily the use of weapons

STEP 3: Brainstorm for Relevant Content (5 brainstorming techniques)

PRESM/6 Players/IFCNG:

Political/Military

- Sovereignty and defence are practically mutually exclusive throughout the course of history – many countries and nations today invest in weapons but hardly have to use it for actual warfare (e.g. Singapore, Malaysia), the idea that investment in weapons is a clear sign of deterrence to potential aggressors and a symbol of sovereignty (e.g. national crests and symbols often contain coat of arms)
- The converse could be true if the same intent to safeguard national sovereignty through the defence of demarcated borders is used in the expansion of these borders, through aggression and territorial acquisition

Political/Economic/Social

- Diplomacy and its continuing trend, through the use of various global economic cooperation platforms and sanctions, could help to allay intentions of using weapons for aggressive intentions, *despite* continued investment in them
- There is varying (and vacillating) success in getting countries to discontinue or at least, decelerate the investment in nuclear weapons (e.g. March 2018, U.S. President Donald Trump agreed to meet with North Korea's Kim Jong-un to seek a deal on denuclearisation, while stressing US sanctions will remain in place. Trump accepted an invitation from Kim to have face-to-face talks and praised the North Korean leader's willingness to discuss denuclearisation and cease his nuclear missile testing program)
- As countries become more porous due to globalisation, continued investment in weapons may not actually mean a greater propensity for war, as many countries contain a large mix of populations that may come from different nations; countries with aggressive intent may need to think twice in waging war against other countries which may host their citizens, or people with relational ties to their citizens

STEP 4: Decide on Thesis

THESIS: ...war can ultimately be avoided even when countries continue to invest in weapons because of the common goal to achieve international peace and stability.

STEP 5: Organise Content

Qualified Thesis: Yes

Intro + Thesis (GIST)

I/G: In the context of this question, I shall define 'war' as an open conflict between two or more belligerents. Going to war is never an easy option for a country especially in this modern era, where the world is highly globalised and deeply interconnected. War brings about dire consequences, from violence and atrocities to casualties and sufferings.

S: While there have been many who lament that war cannot be avoided when countries continue to invest in weapons because of the contribution of heightened tensions, others might also say that we could prevent war with efforts being made to minimise the possibility of wars when countries do invest in weapons.

T: This essay shall seek to posit that war can ultimately be avoided even when countries continue to invest in weapons because of the common goal to achieve internal peace and stability.

Thesis

** Writer has chosen not to start with a distinctive 'G', but the 'I' is sufficiently meaningful, mature and engaging to warrant a thoughtful response from the reader*

T: Provides an overarching qualifying reason to support the stand taken

Supporting BP1: Reasons for No + Evidence

P (T.S.): Undeniably, when countries continue to invest in weapons, this contributes directly to a heightening of tensions between two or more countries.

L (concluding sentence): It can thus be seen that with the continued investment in weapons, countries take it one step closer to making war unavoidable.

Supporting BP2: Reasons for No + Evidence

P (T.S.): In addition, detractors believe that when countries continue in their pursuit of investment in weapons, it makes war unavoidable as they have a specific aim, which is usually to protect their sovereignty.

L (concluding sentence): It makes war inevitable when countries invested in weapons in order to achieve their national aim, at the expense of peace and stability.

Supporting BP3: Reason for Yes + Evidence

P (T.S.): It is internationally recognised that there have been constant and continued efforts to prevent war even when countries do continue to invest in weapons.

L (concluding sentence): These efforts present the success of diplomacy as a means of preventing war even when a country continues to invest in weapons. It also proves that countries are willing to mitigate such situations in order to achieve a win-win situation.

Supporting BP4: Reason for Yes + Evidence

P (T.S.): Countries continue to opine that their investment in weapons is in the name of self-defence, which does not equate to war with another country.

L (concluding sentence): Thus, it is imperative for both countries, which are not capable of striking back, to invest more in weapons for their own self-defence.

Supporting BP5: Reason for Yes + Evidence

P (T.S.): Additionally, war can be avoided even when countries continue to invest in weapons when sanctions are imposed upon them.

L (concluding sentence): Thus, economic sanctions are effective in preventing war when they seek to limit countries from continuing the expansion of their weapons.

Your Arguments

(State when it is NO)

** A qualified NO that admits YES to a small extent, hence showing balance within the argument*

Your Arguments

(State when it is YES)

** Note that the organisation of points of argument also conveys thoughtfulness and evaluation. The key thesis argument that is also the most far-reaching is placed first*

Conclusion: Considering these situations, I maintain largely Yes.

In conclusion, while we acknowledge that there is a possibility of war occurring when countries continue to invest in weapons, we also have to bear in mind the stark realities of the global environment that makes more sense for countries to cooperate and keep the benefits of mutual inter-dependency.

There have also been measures to ensure that countries do not cross the limit when investing in their arms, making war avoidable. Perhaps, to achieve international peace and stability, countries should consider the consequences of going to war and show a little bit more of restraint.

Reiterate Thesis

**** Reiterates the key overarching ideas that anchor the main thesis through paraphrasing, avoiding unnecessary listing and repetition***

Can war be avoided when countries continue to invest in weapons?

In the context of this question, I shall define 'war' as an open conflict between two or more belligerents. Going to war is never an easy option for a country especially in this modern era, where the world is highly globalised and deeply interconnected. War brings about dire consequences, from violence and atrocities to casualties and sufferings. There have been instances where the world has witnessed wars, including the two world wars and even the Cuban Missile Crisis (which thankfully, did not result in war). While there have been many who lament that war cannot be avoided when countries continue to invest in weapons because of the contribution of heightened tensions, others might also say that we could prevent war with efforts being made to minimise the possibility of wars when countries do invest in weapons. This essay shall seek to posit that war can ultimately be avoided even when countries continue to invest in weapons because of the common goal to achieve internal peace and stability.

Undeniably, when countries continue to invest in weapons, this contributes directly to a heightening of tensions between two or more countries. This is simply because it is a tit-for-tat movement, where both countries refuse to back down in an effort to preserve their dignity and prestige. Countries will deem it as their inherent right to protect their sovereignty when face with a possible threat of weapons of mass destruction at their 'doorsteps'. This is best encapsulated with the situation on the Korean Peninsula currently. The Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK) or North Korea, has claimed that it has successfully developed a Hydrogen-bomb in August 2017, along with the launching of two short-range Intercontinental Ballistic Missile (ICBM). This is responded by the U.S. through the building up of armed forces in the Republic of Korea (ROK) or South Korea. U.S. President Donald Trump has even threatened the DPRK that the U.S. would 'unleash fire and fiery like the world has never seen before.' This constant heightening of tensions along the Korean Peninsula has already become the norm and it makes one indifferent should a war truly break out in the region. It can thus be seen that with the continued investment in weapons, countries take it one step closer to making war unavoidable.

In addition, detractors believe that when countries continue in their pursuit of investment in weapons, it makes war unavoidable as they have a specific aim, which is usually to protect their sovereignty. Countries usually regard their investment in weapons as a

Conditional

✓ Shows awareness of context and clear understanding of keywords in the question.

✓ Acknowledges different perspectives clearly without contradiction before taking a clear stand.

✓ An appropriate transition word used at the start of the body paragraph to provide concession. This helps to make the overall essay a more persuasive one.

A relevant example cited but a range of similar situations could also be given in addition to this one example about the North-South Korean tensions.

✓ A clear link back to the condition made in the question.

✓ Student further demonstrates understanding of why countries are in conflict/ war.

legitimate reason to protect themselves from an external threat. Therefore, they will strive for ways and means to defend themselves from those threats. This is evident in the India-Pakistani War over Kashmir, which both countries view the disputed area as an inseparable part of their nation. They set up camps and pointed arms at each other, which eventually resulted in conflict. If the purpose of weaponising is to achieve control over resources, the consequences would be even more cataclysmic as a country would unilaterally invade another country, thus sparking a war. This can be seen in the 1990 First Gulf War, when Iraq invaded Kuwait to gain control of their oil resources. In the process, Iraq, under the leadership of Saddam Hussein, used chemical weapons such as sarin gas, against unarmed innocent civilians. It makes war inevitable when countries invested in weapons in order to achieve their national aim, at the expense of peace and stability.

✓ A very apt illustration provided.

However, the notion of countries going to war over investment in weapons would seem far-fetched, especially when the world is highly connected. The volatility, uncertainty, complexity and ambiguity in today's world would motivate countries to cooperate with each other, despite the constant investment and upgrade in their weapons. This would be discussed in the subsequent paragraphs below.

✓ A paragraph to show balance and effective links were made to current trends in the modern world.

Last sentence awkwardly expressed.

It is internationally recognised that there have been constant and continued efforts to prevent war even when countries do continue to invest in weapons. These measures do work to ensure that while countries continue their investment in weapons, it would be limited so that countries will not use their weapons to go to war easily or recklessly. One such example would be through diplomacy, where countries lay out their differences such that even with the escalation of arms, war is avoided. We see such efforts internationally, where the United Nation's hopes to achieve a 'nuclear-free world' with the signing of treaties such as the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty and the Strategic Arms Limitation Talks (SALT) which sets a limit to a country's nuclear arms. Regionally, we see the efforts by ASEAN countries and China to hammer out a Code of Conduct Framework for the South China Sea, in the wake of China's heavy militarisation of the South China Sea. The six-party talks previously also hope to denuclearise the Korean Peninsula, when the DPRK accelerated their investment in her nuclear programme. Most recently, both China and India have backed down from months-long standoff over at the disputed Doklam Plateau (Tri-junction between China, India and Bhutan). These efforts present the success of diplomacy as a means of preventing war even when a country continues to invest in weapons. It also proves that countries are willing to mitigate such situations in order to achieve a win-win situation.

A transition word or phrase could be used to transit more effectively from the previous linking paragraph. The elaboration of this point made needs to be more concise as well.

✓ Good range of specific illustrations which showcases relevant content knowledge.

Countries continue to opine that their investment in weapons is in the name of self-defence, which does not equate to war with another country. They justify their actions due to changing geopolitical realities in their surroundings, which they do not possess control over. This is exemplified in the case of post-war Japan, which does not allow her to have a standing army. However, given the recent tensions in the region, Japan does not have a choice but to invest more in her Self Defence Force, in order to protect herself from an invasion. Similarly, the U.S. arms sales to Taiwan (Republic of China) estimating two billion USD is also seen as a form of protection from Mainland China (People's Republic of China) which sees the island as a renegade province and will not hesitate to use force if it declares independence. This comes especially in the context of the election of pro-independent President Tsai Yingwen in Taiwan. Thus, it is imperative for both countries, which are not capable of striking back, to invest more in weapons for their own self-defence.

Further elaboration of this example of post-war Japan needed to show how it is linked to the argument made in this paragraph.

Additionally, war can be avoided even when countries continue to invest in weapons when sanctions are imposed upon them. These sanctions, usually economic, make it harder for countries, especially rogue states, to continue their investment in weapons. Examples are economic sanctions against Russia and North Korea. In addition, the Joint Countries Points of Agreement (JCPOA) led by the U.S. limits the amount of nuclear weapons that Iran is supposed to possess. Thus, economic sanctions are effective in preventing war when they seek to limit countries from continuing the expansion of their weapons.

This body paragraph lacks the development, elaboration and depth that the other body paragraphs had, which affects overall cogency needed to score an A.

In conclusion, while we acknowledge that there is a possibility of war occurring when countries continue to invest in weapons, we also have to bear in mind the stark realities of the global environment that makes more sense for countries to cooperate and keep the benefits of mutual inter-dependency. There have also been measures to ensure that countries do not cross the limit when investing in their arms, making war avoidable. Perhaps, to achieve international peace and stability, countries should consider the consequences of going to war and show a little bit more of restraint.

✓ A concise and cogent conclusion with clear resolution provided.

GRADE: B (High)

Learning Points:



Consistently answering the question, well-substantiated and largely cogent. Effective use of language and vocabulary.



Well-developed BPs are not consistent throughout the essay. (i.e. the last 2 BPs)

Is the media still credible today?

From the alleged endorsement of Donald Trump by Pope Francis to the implementation of censorship by the major powers of the globe, the world we live in today is indeed fraught with major obstacles in our consumption of the media. In the light of such a trend, many ardently contend that the media is no longer credible today due to the barriers set up by governments as well as the rampant circulation of fake news online. Others, on the other hand, assert that the media is still credible today as the media champions the freedom of expression and many social causes. Nevertheless, I still firmly maintain my stance that the media is still credible today as it advocates many causes that were not seen as viable in the past.

Before one delves into the issues, it is important to note why critics tend to argue that the media is no longer credible today. In the past, the media was not so widely controlled by the governments as it was not readily available to the citizens. Today however, it is argued that the media is subjected to the political manipulation of the Powers That Be and is merely becoming a politicised mouthpiece of the government to ensure that the authority and legitimacy of the government can be maintained. Such an argument can be reflected in various examples in society. For example, China's implementation of the Great Firewall to ban any information that may be a threat to its authority can be likened to the restriction of information on the Umbrella Movement that happened in Hong Kong was to prevent the citizens from expressing their political dissent on the Chinese government that would otherwise result in social instability. The examples above serve to reinforce the argument that the media is no longer reliable today as it is constantly under control by governments.

Critics also posit that the media is no longer credible today as the media today engenders conformity due to the rampant circulation of the fake news culture. This results in the readers not being able to critically have their own point of view, but rather they choose to conform to the information that are presented. This also gives rise to a voyeuristic culture whereby people tend to move towards tabloid news rather than news that really matter. The argument above can be reflected in various examples in society such as the endorsement of Donald Trump by Pope Francis which is completely untrue and was a piece of news posted to stir up commercial interest of such news outlets or media platforms. Another example is the increase in popularity of magazines such as The Sun and Apple Daily which provide insights into the lives of celebrities. While the media is no longer credible today, it was credible in the past as the media was limited to newspapers and television ensuring that people are able to consume information that are politically correct. Hence, the above examples seek to reinforce the argument that the media is no longer credible today due to the fake news culture.

Context of Time

✓ Shows awareness of today's context

✓ Shows awareness of both sides of the argument

Concept of credibility not clearly defined

✓ Students shows a change in context of the past and that of the present, thus addressing the context of time trigger word 'still'.

Distinction of eg 1 and eg 2 is not clear, and examples are limited to one country – China.

Logical link between 'fake news', 'conformity' and 'credibility' not clearly explained.

This example of tabloid magazines is not developed or linked to the question.
A better flow could have been achieved if student compared the past and present state of the media immediately after the topic sentence, rather than towards the end of the BP.

While I acknowledge the truth in the arguments above, one has to take a broader view that the media is still credible today as it promotes the diversity of opinions and also espouses freedom of expression. Compared to the past where there was only traditional media, such views were not readily available in traditional media. Hence, the diversity of opinions in today's media helps readers get an alternative viewpoint into issues which are not presented on mainstream media. The argument above can be reinforced by various examples such as the online forum Reddit that allows users to share their opinions on any issue without the need to worry about regulations set up by the government. Also, independent online news websites such as The Online Citizen in Singapore provide an alternative viewpoint into issues such as the Amos Yee scandal where many people disagreed with the actions taken by the government to prosecute a 16-year-old student for his defaming comments on the government. It provides checks and balances of the government to ensure that they are kept accountable for their actions. The examples above seek to reinforce the crux of my argument that the media today is credible as it promotes the culture of freedom of expression by allowing citizens to express their viewpoints online.

Furthermore, many also argue that the media is still credible today as social media aids in championing many social causes that ensure that the rights of the marginalised are being met, such as the Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual and Transsexual (LGBT) groups as well as women within many societies. In the past, due to the limitations in the media, the rights of these marginalised groups were often being overlooked and they were at times not acknowledged for what they deserved. The Black Lives Matter campaign exposes the ugly side of the US police department as the white policemen are said to be firing shots at black men despite them not posing a threat. Such incidents are testament to the deep-seated prejudice borne from oppression of minorities. However, without today's social media, such incidents would often have been covered up in the past to prevent social unrest. Another example would be the #HeForShe campaign endorsed by Jennifer Lawrence which advocates for equal rights between the two genders to ensure that the rights of the marginalised are being met. The two examples above certainly enforce the argument that the media is still credible today as it constantly gives a voice to the marginalised to ensure that their rights are protected.

Lastly, some also argue that the media is still credible today due to the work of investigative journalists who seek to unearth the hidden secrets of various institutions that undermine the rights of others. Compared to the past, investigative journalism was not so widespread due to the conservative mind-sets of the people. Such an argument is reflected in various examples in society such as the Catholic church scandal of 2002 exposed by the Boston Globe, which was even converted into a movie to show the struggles that the journalist had to go through to unearth the truth. Another example is the hunting of dolphins near the bays of Japan. Investigative journalists unearthed the dark side of the Japanese fishing industry to put a stop to such environmentally irresponsible actions. The examples above certainly prove that the media is still

Student reconciles the opposing view with his stand.

✓ An effective evaluation of past-present contexts shows how today's media freedom makes the media more credible.

Unnecessary to attribute the argument to others when it aligns with the student's own thesis - simply stating/implying it as one's own argument and reason makes it more emphatic and assertive.

A clearer link between these examples and 'credibility' (i.e. believability) of the media needs to be drawn in the explanation – How does giving a voice to the marginalised make the media credible?

Unnecessary to attribute the argument to others when it aligns with the student's own thesis.

credible today as it helps in exposing the negative sides of industries, which was a feat unachievable in the past. The debate here has certainly shed light on the various issues regarding the credibility of the media. Granted, the rampant circulation of fake news and political censorship seeks to undermine the credibility of the media today. Nevertheless, I firmly remain my stance that the media is still credible in today's society. Grade: B (Low)	✓ A concise conclusion that is effective in reiterating the thesis. ✓ Overall, student consistently addresses the context of time requirement in the question.
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Learning Points:



Context of time consistently addressed. Specific examples were given. Clear balance and well-managed arguments. Effective use of language.



Examples were not consistently well linked or explained in alignment to what 'media credibility' entails. (i.e. If the situation in the question is about 'credibility', ensure that all examples clearly reflect how the media is credible (or not), and not merely beneficial or useful). This could be because the notion of 'credibility' was not clearly defined in the outset at the introductory paragraph.

Are national boundaries still relevant today?

STEP 2: Analyse the Question Requirements (QTK)

Q => Yes or No. Distinction between degrees of ability for greater evaluation

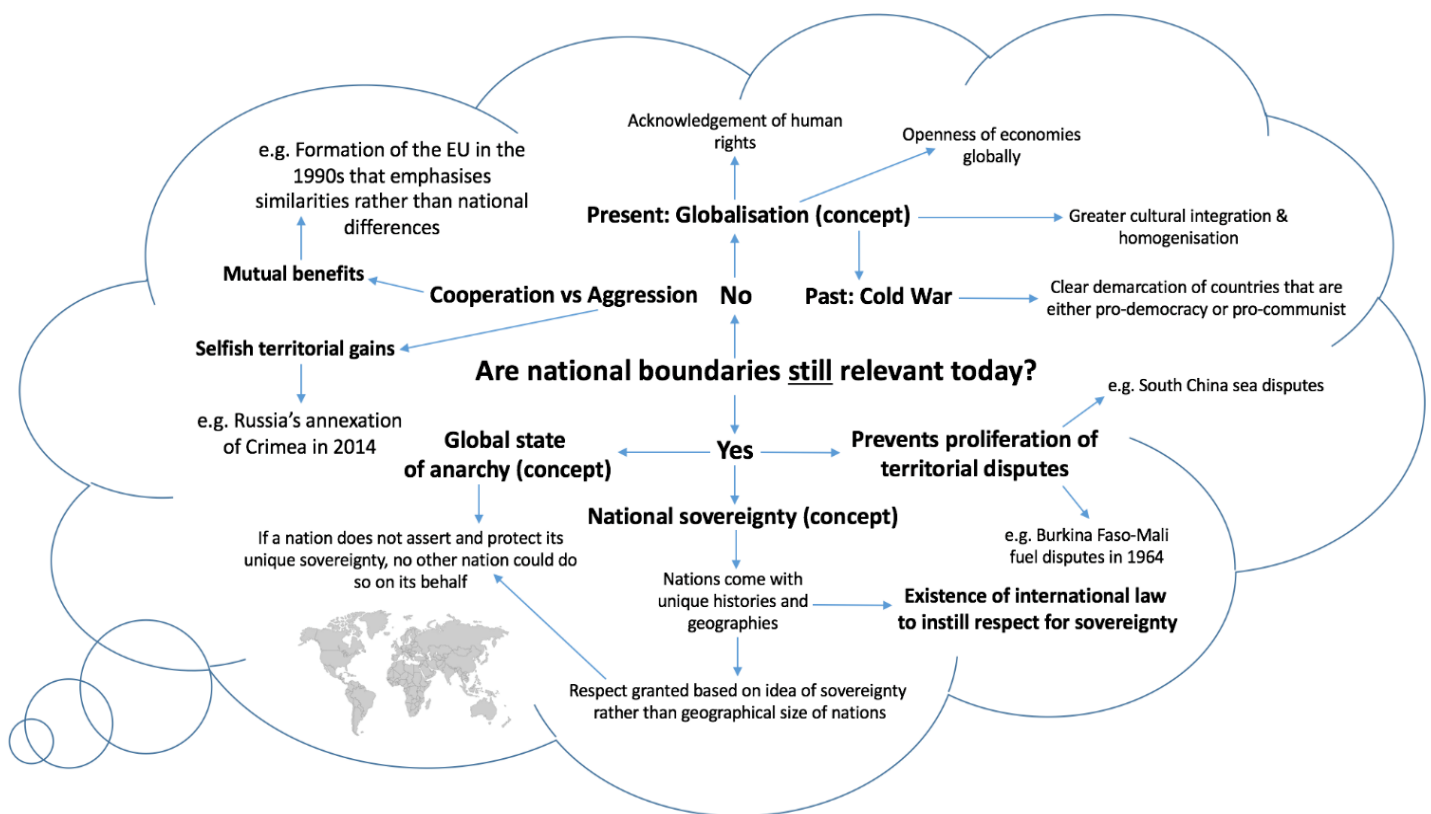
T => National boundaries, sovereignty, geopolitics, globalisation, international versus national interests and culture

K => Relevant = has currency and value, up-to-date, assumes widespread changes to have taken place in order to trigger this thought, and questions if national boundaries are still functional

Still = Continues to be, assumption that it was relevant in the past (writer will have to determine if this is true and how long ago this was the case), denotes comparison, usually with the present

Today = Focus on the present context

STEP 3: Brainstorm for Relevant Content (5 brainstorming techniques)



STEP 4: Decide on Thesis

THESIS: Therefore, I agree that national boundaries are still relevant today because it is underpinned by the principle of a country's sovereignty.

STEP 5: Organise Content

Qualified Thesis: Yes

<u>Intro + Thesis (GIST)</u> G: The concept of national boundaries was relatively new when it was proposed by then President of the United States Woodrow Wilson at the Treaty of Versailles after World War 1. I: In the context of this question, I shall define 'national boundaries' as the deliberate outline of a country's physical territorial borders. S: While it is true that we increasingly view the use of national boundaries as less relevant today as compared to the past, it is still essential for countries to do so as it sets the limits of the extent of their influence. T: Therefore, I agree that national boundaries are <u>still</u> relevant today <u>because it is underpinned by the principle of a country's sovereignty</u> .	<u>Thesis</u>
<u>Supporting BP1: Reason for No + Evidence</u> P (T.S.): Undeniably, it is true that with globalisation, our world has become so much more interconnected. This has led to the <u>perceived</u> abolishment of national boundaries. L (concluding sentence): Thus, it is proven that with greater integration and cultural homogenisation of countries, national boundaries may not seem to be relevant anymore today.	<u>Your Arguments</u> <u>(State when it is NO)</u> <i>*Notice how the writer uses words like 'perceived' to show critique and analysis and consequently, increase the persuasiveness of the argument</i>
<u>Supporting BP2: Reason for No + Evidence</u> P (T.S.): In addition, some may also opine that national boundaries are not relevant today when countries do not accept and respect them. L (concluding sentence): Therefore, naysayers might argue that national boundaries are no longer relevant today due to their desire for personal gains.	
<u>Supporting BP3: Reason for Yes + Evidence</u> P (T.S.): I fully concur that national boundaries are still relevant today as it demarcates a country's territory. L (concluding sentence): Thus, it can be safe to say that despite a change in the global political landscape, the principle of territorial sovereignty and the emphasis on protecting a country's national boundaries are of <u>utmost</u> priority in the world today, proving that national boundaries are still relevant today.	<u>Your Arguments</u> <u>(State when it is YES)</u>
<u>Supporting BP4: Reason for Yes + Evidence</u> P (T.S.): Furthermore, I agree that national boundaries are still relevant today as it prevents occurrence of the proliferation of territorial disputes. L (concluding sentence): Thus, national boundaries are still relevant today with the intent of clearly making sure that a country does not step out of her limits to pursuit her quest for personal interests.	
<u>Conclusion: Considering these situations, I maintain largely Yes.</u> In conclusion, <u>despite</u> the questionable functions of national boundaries in this borderless world today, it <u>still remains</u> as a <u>vital component of</u> a country's sovereignty that cannot be violated upon even in the world today. Therefore, it is essential for countries to coordinate and define their national boundaries to ensure the continuation of international peace and security.	<u>Reiterate Thesis</u> <i>* Writer concludes, upon considering opposite viewpoints, reiterating forcefully the thesis while ending off with a suggestion and qualification that reinforces it (e.g. 'to ensure the continuation of international peace and security')</i>

Are national boundaries still relevant today?

In the context of this question, I shall define 'national boundaries' as the deliberate outline of a country's physical territorial borders. The concept of national boundaries was relatively new when it was proposed by then President of the United States Woodrow Wilson at the Treaty of Versailles after World War 1. Under his proposal of '14 points', it gave rise to the concept of 'self-determination' where people could decide the borders of their countries. While it is true that we increasingly view the use of national boundaries as less relevant today as compared to the past, it is still essential for countries to do so as it sets the limits of the extent of their influence. Therefore, I agree that national boundaries are still relevant today because it is underpinned by the principle of a country's sovereignty.

Undeniably, it is true that with globalisation, our world has become so much more interconnected. This has led to the perceived abolishment of national boundaries. Gone were the days where people still had to be mindful of which country they set foot into. For example, during the Cold War in the 20th century, the Berlin wall in Germany was a symbol of the bipolar divide of the international order. The boundaries that the superpowers had set within Germany was therefore a divide between the Capitalist West and the Communist East of Europe. In contrast, the openness of our economies around the world has resulted in the decrease in the scrutiny of a country's national boundaries. This is exemplified with the ongoing Syria Civil War which has resulted in an exodus of immigrants into Europe via the open borders of Germany. Similarly, the alleged abuse of Rohingyas in Myanmar has also increased the flow of these migrants into neighbouring countries such as Malaysia and Bangladesh through their porous borders. Thus, it is proven that with greater integration and cultural homogenisation of countries, national boundaries may not seem to be relevant anymore today.

In addition, some may also opine that national boundaries are not relevant today when countries do not accept and respect them. This results in a deliberate attempt to overlook national boundaries to attain their own personal gains. For example, the success story of the integration of Europe to form the European Union in the 1990s that was championed by the late German Chancellor Helmut Kohl formed the basis of greater cooperation for countries to achieve economic growth. In contrast, in 2014, Russia's annexation of Crimea proved that her hunger for self-interest was insatiable. Her perception was that it was all right to

Context of Time

The student could have started the introduction with the example of the Treaty of Versailles and weave in the definition of 'national boundaries' more naturally into the introduction.

✓ Clear comparative words/phrases used to acknowledge the context 'still'.

✓ Good contrast between the past and the present.

✓ Appropriate use of the word 'seem' in the last sentence that highlights the concession that the student is making in this paragraph.

✓ A succinct and relevant point made to show balance.

Student could have elaborated further on what 'personal gains' mean.

not respect a country's boundaries for personal gains. Therefore, naysayers might argue that national boundaries are no longer relevant today due to their desire for personal gains.

However, the above mentioned points are flawed in today's world because there are instruments of law put in place to ensure that countries respect each other's national borders according to international law. This includes the establishment of the International Court of Justice under the United Nations to ensure international peace and stability. It also acts as a deterrence against potential aggressors that might want to disrespect another country's national boundaries.

I fully concur that national boundaries are still relevant today as it demarcates a country's territory. It asserts a country's territorial sovereignty which cannot be infringed or violated upon by other countries. In the past, regional powers like the Ottoman Empire and the Austria-Hungarian Empire took great pride in establishing their spheres of influence within their respective boundaries to avoid any potential conflict. Today, it is still true in the context of the modern world. Great powers like India to even small players on the international stage like Singapore take great effort in security their borders. This is further exemplified by Singapore's Foreign Minister Vivian Balakrishnan who asserted that Singaporeans themselves need to defend the nation themselves in a press conference recently in July 2017; his address echoes many other ministers who expressed the same view since Singapore's independence in 1965. Thus, it can be safe to say that despite a change in the global political landscape, the principle of territorial sovereignty and the emphasis on protecting a country's national boundaries are of utmost priority in the world today, proving that national boundaries are still relevant today.

Furthermore, I agree that national boundaries are still relevant today as it prevents occurrence of the proliferation of territorial disputes. Territorial disputes generally exist due to the involvement of scarce and precious national resources that countries want to take advantage of and exploit. This can be seen from the Burkina Faso – Mali frontier dispute which involved copious amounts of natural gas and oil deposits in 1964. Similarly, China today claims the whole of the South and East China seas, much to the protests of her neighbours like Vietnam and Japan respectively. This is because it is a known fact that natural gas and oil reserves also lay beneath the South China Sea today. The above examples occurred due to unclear demarcation of boundaries, thus motivating the country to find loopholes and to take advantage of it. Thus, national boundaries are still relevant today with the intent of clearly making sure that a country does not step out of her limits to pursuit her quest for personal interests.

A rather brief paragraph to show transition to the supporting argument. Point made was relevant but lack adequate elaboration and depth of discussion.

✓ A strong and clear stand provided.

✓ Range of examples provided to strengthen argument.

✓ Examples provided are written in a succinct and effective manner with no unnecessary details.

In conclusion, despite the questionable functions of national boundaries in this borderless world today, it still remains as a vital component of a country's sovereignty that cannot be violated upon even in the world today. Therefore, it is essential for countries to coordinate and define their national boundaries to ensure the continuation of international peace and security.

GRADE: B (High)

✓ Deliberate use of comparative phrases again to show clear and consistent links to the context 'still'.

Learning Points:



Context of time consistently addressed. Clear examples provided and well-linked to the question requirements. Clear balance and well-managed arguments. Effective use of language.



Explanations could have been clearer in some BPs (i.e. BP2 and 3). Introduction could have been better in generating interest of reader.

Ng Hua Lin 17S08

To what extent is Singapore ready in responding to security threats?

In today's context, the main security threat that countries face is terrorism. Terrorism, in its simplest definition, is the systematic use of violence and intimidation to achieve political or ideological goals. Terrorism is an increasingly rampant and prominent threat in today's context. In this era of technological revolution, the spate of terrorist attacks is all too common a sight. Many anti-terrorism countries such as Singapore, known to adopt a strong stance against terrorism are responding to security threats through counterterrorism efforts such as surveillance and more stringent checks. However, even with multiplied efforts of the Singapore government in countering terrorism, there is still an increasing number of people being radicalised. Therefore, I hold on to the view that my society, Singapore, is not ready in responding to security threats by a large extent.

Singapore is prepared in responding to security threats to a small extent. The Singapore government has been resourceful and proactive in combating security threats. For instance, there are more stringent checks at immigration checkpoints such as Changi Airport and Tuas. There is also a greater number of vigilant police and security officers patrolling the community and public areas such as Mass Rapid Transit (MRT) stations. These measures aid in detecting and apprehending suspicious figures. Such practices also keep Singaporeans alert and capable of swiftly tracking potential criminals. In addition, online surveillance has been intensified where telephone and internet activities are monitored closely. This is to respond to radicalised terrorists who have moved online to propagate their ideology and seek supporters among the youth and vulnerable groups through their carefully crafted content. Therefore, with various preventive measures in place, Singapore is ready in responding to security threats.

With all that being said, on the other side of the spectrum, Singapore is not ready in responding to security threats due to the counter effects that Singapore might face when eradicating security threats. One way Singapore can respond to security threats is to remove online propaganda websites entirely. While this seems like an ideal situation, it is easier said than done. An illustration would be apt; an ancient Greek mythological creature, the Hydra, was almost invincible for the properties it had. For every one attempt to remove its head, two would sprout out immediately. This is a figurative representation of the internet-fuelled terrorists' propagation. For every website being weeded out, more will pop out. The nature of the internet allows the propagation of extremist views to flourish in cyberspace. Terrorists know it very well and use the Internet to its fullest advantage. Therefore, with the nature of the Internet, it is difficult for Singapore to respond to security threats such as internet-facilitated radicalism.

Simple Polarity

The scope of argument is narrow, pertaining only to terrorism. Scope can be broadened to other areas like cybersecurity, spread of fake news and even regional tensions.

✓Balance clearly and succinctly fleshed out

Link is not well qualified, and hence has shifted position of argument to (completely) agreeing with the statement.

Transition and balance is not well managed; hence a contradiction is apparent. Student should qualify the topic sentence more clearly.

In fact, Singapore is not ready to respond to security threats because of the inherent limitations that counter-terrorist efforts have against prominent groups such as Islamic States of Syria and Iraq (ISIS). The first line of defence that Singapore takes in response to security threats are intelligence-gathering and online surveillance. However, it is impossible to track everyone's online activity and monitor which individual in Singapore has been radicalised. This would also infringe on the peoples' right of privacy should such a course of action be taken. Such a forecast is valid since various countries at risk of terrorist attacks such as the British and the United States of America (USA) had had plans to ban encryption techniques on various social media platforms such as WhatsApp to monitor terrorism. This resulted in displeasure and protests among its citizens. Hence, it is not unlikely that Singapore will follow suit with its citizens being highly vocal and willing to fight for their right to privacy. Thus, Singapore is not yet ready to respond to the tall order of security threats today.

There are also inadequate measures taken by Singapore to respond to security threats. Even with more stringent checks and online surveillance, the number of people travelling to the warzones in the Middle East continues to grow. The ideology of terrorism continues to propagate even in Singapore, where cases of Singaporeans being arrested due to self-radicalisation are evident. Despite the government being vigilant, terrorists still have the ability to influence malleable groups in Singapore. Furthermore, online surveillance is ineffective against lone wolf attacks. Without terror linked to terrorist organisations, perpetrators can easily slip pass Singapore's security system undetected and unleash mayhem. In recent years, lone wolf attacks make up a large proportion of security threats. Therefore, Singapore is not ready in responding to security threats as it is an unstoppable pandemic.

Lastly, Singapore is not prepared to respond to security threats as current counterterrorism efforts do not address the root cause of terrorism. The civil war between Bashar Al Assad and rebels have been going on for years. This might be largely due to the underlying economic and social issues left unaddressed. The civilians can either fight for or against the government. Singapore can respond to such security threats by condemning the Assad government. However, this form of interference might bring more detriment than benefits as it only benefits a few groups. Condemning will inevitably cause deeper resentment, resulting in greater divisiveness and destruction to civilians' lives. This might result in more and more of the disillusioned joining terrorist efforts and propagating their extremist ideology. This will then increase security threats in countries such as Singapore. Hence, Singapore is not prepared to respond to security threats due to the perennial political entanglements that exist.

All in all, with our human history of bloodshed, violence, destruction and sufferings, it asserts that humans are intrinsically compelled to use violence as a solution to problems. We see parallels even in the modern context: the struggle and desire of terrorist groups to create an Islamic caliphate to bring said peace and equity to adherents of its religious ideology through cleverly disguised,

✓Effective evaluation and analysis of the local context by comparing with similar situations in other developed countries.

✓Student increasingly shows a depth of understanding of the workings and strategic nature of terror in the modern world. This works in favour of the student despite the narrow focus on terrorism, as it opens up many angles of argument. In other words, there is more depth than breadth in this essay.

A clear overview of points should have been presented

compact bombs. To root out the real cause of security threats would require deeper understanding of the underlying differences and find solutions to reconcile these differences. Terrorism, like a cancer, is all too omnipresent in today's world to eliminate. Thus, Singapore can only be marginally effective in response to security threats. Overall, I hold on to the view that Singapore is not ready to respond to security threats to a large extent.

Grade: B (High)

✓ Conviction and flair in the writing emphasises a strong personal insight.

Learning Points:



Overall, a comprehensive and well-substantiated essay. There was a depth of discussion, showing good understanding of the topic. Effective use of language.



Topic sentences, Links and paragraph transitions should have been better qualified to avoid contradictory statements. This essay also lacked scope of discussion.

'Whoever controls the media controls the world.' To what extent do you agree?

STEP 2: Analyse the Question Requirements (QTK)

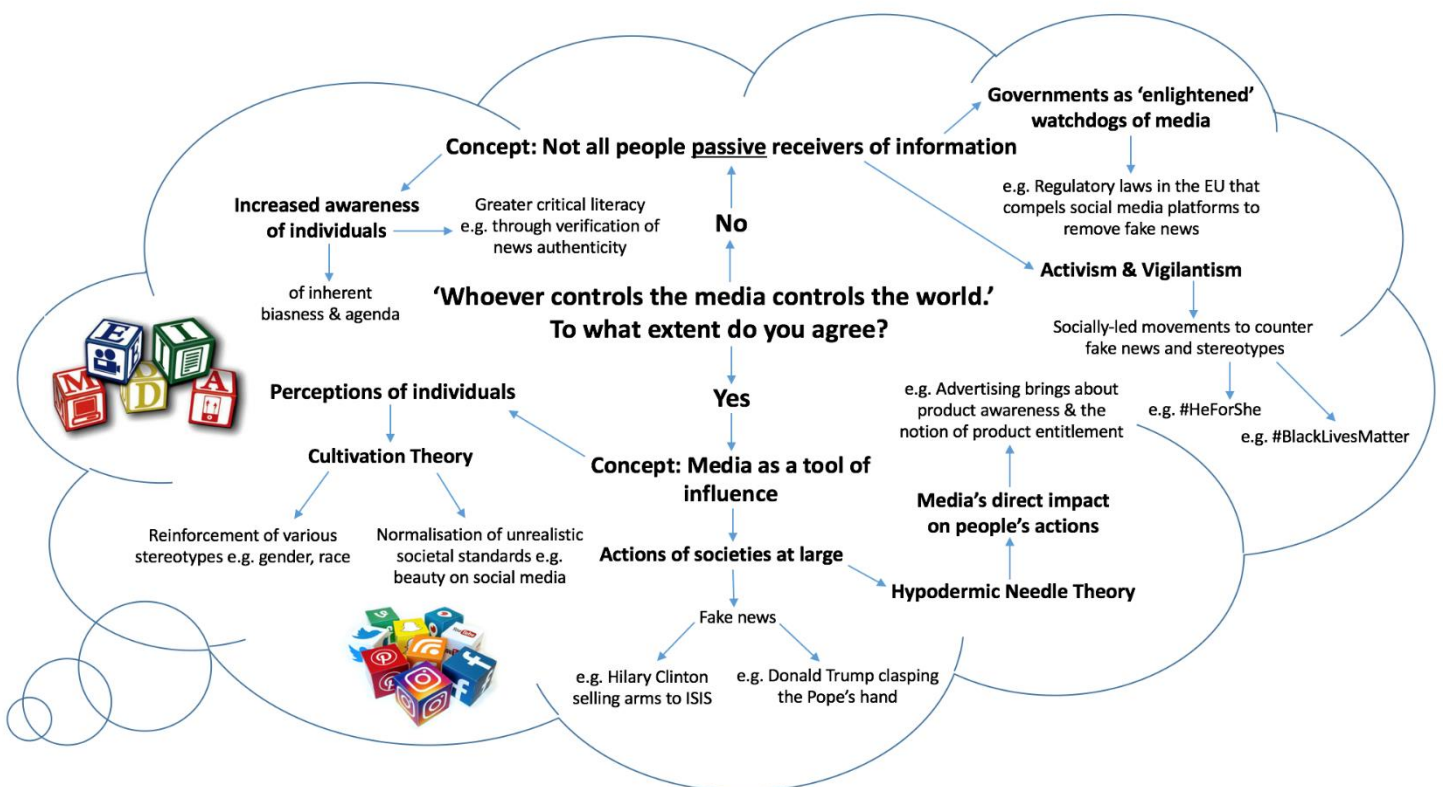
Q => Agree to a large or small extent. The extent of control requires evaluation of various arguments and examples in the world to derive a cogent overall stand.

T => Considering increasing technological advancement and stakeholders, the media's ability to exert influence and control.

K => Control = assumes a clear relationship of cause and effect between the media and the power it wields over the people who have access to it. Control understood in various senses, including but not limited to mental control, which eventually transpires into behavioral control as well.

Whoever = assumes that media is a tool, that can be tapped upon by all stakeholders at will, with agenda and purpose of their own.

STEP 3: Brainstorm for Relevant Content (5 brainstorming techniques)



STEP 4: Decide on Thesis

THESIS: I agree to a large extent that whoever controls the media, controls the world.

STEP 5: Organise Content

Qualified Thesis: Yes

Intro + Thesis (GIST)

G: With the advent of technology, there are now greater variety of channels of media ranging from traditional media such as print and broadcast media, to new media such as the Internet.

I: The media has the ability to reach a large audience, which grants whoever controls the media control over the world through influencing the perception and actions of individuals.

S: However, some may argue that with increasing awareness of false media perception and vigilantism, ultimately, given the wide reach of the media and its ability to influence perceptions and actions regardless of the increasing awareness and vigilantism,

T: I agree to a large extent that whoever controls the media, controls the world.

Thesis

G: *Brings in technology, and sets the context for the topic of media and control*

I/S: *Links and interprets how media through technology is able to exert control, and what control entails*

S: *The opposing context is nuanced, however, greater clarity could be shown by breaking up the long sentence*

T: *A clear and qualified stand*

Supporting BP1: Reason for Yes + Evidence

P (T.S.): Whoever controls the media, controls the world by influencing perceptions – the ability to shape the perceptions of individuals to believe and see a false reality.

L (concluding sentence): Therefore, with the ability to change perceptions of large groups of people and societies, whoever controls the media controls the world's perception.

Your Arguments **(State when it is YES)**

**Notice how the first BP argument starts by addressing the keywords and proposition of the question clearly in order to assert a point. Do not shy away from this, as it helps to anchor the argument clearly, paving the way for easier linking back to the question and hence, consistent relevance.*

Supporting BP2: Reason for Yes + Evidence

P (T.S.): Whoever controls the media, is also able to influence actions of large societies and groups of individuals, hence controlling the world.

L (concluding sentence): Hence, with the ability to influence actions taken by large groups of individuals, control over the media will grant control over the actions of the world.

***Broad qualifying reasons support the theses in the topic sentences*

Supporting BP3: Reason for No + Evidence

P (T.S.): However, control over the media does not translate to control over the world due to increased awareness of individuals.

L (concluding sentence): ...the ability of fake news to influence perception and actions of individuals are limited, hence restricting the media from controlling the world.

Your Arguments **(State when it is NO)**

** Remember that a simple discourse marker (e.g. 'However') is all it takes to introduce a counterargument paragraph*

Supporting BP4: Reason for No & Yes (Antithesis + Rebuttal) + Evidence

P (Antithesis): Furthermore, others may also argue that increased vigilantism by individuals is limiting the control media has over the world.

L: ...Thus, the rise of vigilantism limits the influence media has on the perception of individuals, preventing the media from controlling the world.

P (Rebuttal): However, it should be noted that such vigilantism may result in stereotypes and false perceptions as well...

L: ...while the media can switch stands and racial discrimination may be amplified and publicised more even though it is falling, thus creating false perceptions and influencing actions taken by individuals.

Your Arguments **(State when it is NO and Yes)**

**Structuring in a rebuttal effectively creates greater evaluation and support for the overall thesis, but should be attempted with considerable care and thought*

***The net effect of a rebuttal is to reinstate and to strengthen the overall thesis, also shows that the writer has factored balance into the overall argument*

Conclusion: Considering these situations, I maintain largely Yes.

In conclusion, despite the rise in awareness and vigilantism, the influence of the media over perceptions and actions still remains large due to the rise in awareness and vigilantism being unsubstantial in reaching media's influence over perceptions and actions of individuals. Ultimately, the media still has great reach and vast influence over large groups of individuals, hence having the ability to control the world. Thus, I agree to a large extent that whoever controls the world, controls the media.

Reiterate Thesis

** Use of discourse markers (e.g. 'despite', 'still', 'ultimately') reiterates how the writer's analysis has considered opposing arguments and turned it around to support his overall thesis*

***A successful conclusion should not be the result of chance, but envisioned in the planning stage so as to provide a satisfying end to an essay*

Denzel Lim Jie Hao 16A03

‘Whoever controls the media controls the world.’ To what extent do you agree?

With the advent of technology, there are now greater variety of channels of media ranging from traditional media such as print and broadcast media, to new media such as the Internet. The media has the ability to reach a large audience, which grants whoever controls the media control over the world through influencing the perception and actions of individuals. However, some may argue that with increasing awareness of false media perception and vigilantism, ultimately, given the wide reach of the media and its ability to influence perceptions and actions regardless of the increasing awareness and vigilantism, I agree to a large extent that whoever controls the media, controls the world.

Whoever controls the media, controls the world by influencing perceptions – the ability to shape the perceptions of individuals to believe and see a false reality. This is known as the cultivation theory, where the media can portray twisted realities through normalising unrealistic standards such as beauty standards which are unachievable without the help of photo-editing software or going under the knife. Gender roles where women are subservient to men and race stereotypes are further examples of the media changing the perception of individuals. Influencing the perception of a large number of individuals will change the perceptions of societies towards a certain issue or race as seen from the race discrimination which is extremely prominent in America, where African Americans are still being discriminated against due to misrepresentation on the media, as seen from a research by the University of Southern California, where out of 100 top films in 2014, only 12.5% of actors were black. Therefore, with the ability to change perceptions of large groups of people and societies, whoever controls the media controls the world’s perception.

Whoever controls the media, is also able to influence actions of large societies and groups of individuals, hence controlling the world. With the rising trend of fake news, the actions of American voters are influenced as fake news such as Hillary Clinton selling arms to the ISIS and Donald Trump being endorsed by the Pope. Furthermore, according to the hypodermic needle theory, the media has a direct impact on user’s actions. With advertisements, firms are able to influence the purchasing behaviour of individuals. There is greater product awareness and differentiation when firms spend on advertisements, entitling

Simple Polarity

✓ Student demonstrated awareness of features and functions of the media.

Relevant points raised to highlight the other perspectives, but student could have explained in a clearer fashion why he agrees with the statement despite increasing awareness of false media and vigilantism.

✓ Clear point made.

✓ Good range of relevant and effective examples provided.

In order for the hypodermic needle theory example to be used more persuasively, student could have made a concession that although this theory has been largely considered as obsolete for a long time, big data analytics-based mass customisation has led to a modern revival of the basic idea.

✓ Student expanded discussion to a wider group

individuals to purchase their items. Hence, with the ability to influence actions taken by large groups of individuals, control over the media will grant control over the actions of the world.

However, control over the media does not translate to control over the world due to increased awareness of individuals. Some may argue that when reading media through the various outlets, individuals are becoming more aware of the inherent biasness and agenda behind the source. Individuals are also able to discern between real and fake news through verifying more news sources and authenticity of posts. Furthermore, with regulatory bodies and laws being set up against fake news as seen from governments of Germany and the European Union considering laws to compel social networks to take down various types of unlawful content, the ability of fake news to influence perception and actions of individuals are limited, hence restricting the media from controlling the world.

Furthermore, others may also argue that increased vigilantism by individuals is limiting the control media has over the world. Vigilantism, especially over internet, has led to the formation of various organisations or movements in order to tackle issues such as stereotypes or false representation by the media. The creation of the movements such as the #HeForShe campaign which aims to remove gender roles and the #BlackLivesMatter movement, aimed at stopping race discrimination against blacks. These movements spread awareness of the current false interpretation by the media, correcting the false perceptions individuals have. Thus, the rise of vigilantism limits the influence media has on the perception of individuals, preventing the media from controlling the world. However, it should be noted that such vigilantism may result in stereotypes and false perceptions as well, with increasing feministic views and the perception of all men treating women subserviently while the media can switch stands and racial discrimination may be amplified and publicised more even though it is falling, thus creating false perceptions and influencing actions taken by individuals.

In conclusion, despite the rise in awareness and vigilantism, the influence of the media over perceptions and actions still remains large due to the rise in awareness and vigilantism being unsubstantial in reaching media's influence over perceptions and actions of individuals. Ultimately, the media still has great reach and vast influence over large groups of individuals, hence having the ability to control the world. Thus, I agree to a large extent that whoever controls the world, controls the media.

GRADE: A

of stakeholders – businesses/corporations but could have given more specific examples.

✓ Attempt at providing balance with good counter-arguments raised.

✓ Clear transitions to start this body paragraph.

The term 'vigilantism' may not be the most appropriate word to be used to bring across the point made in this paragraph. 'Vigilantism' in its proper definition refers to any person who takes the law into his or her own hands, as by avenging a crime. Based on the examples provided by the student, it appears that 'activism' would be a more suitable word instead.

Student could have also provided examples to justify point made about how "such vigilantism may result in stereotypes and false perceptions".

Thesis clearly reiterated, but further personal insights could have been provided.

Learning Points:



Clear points argued and well supported with broad scope of examples. Shows depth of understanding in discussion. Effective use of language.



Student could have been more consistent in presenting clearer explanations of terms and theories cited. Some minor gaps in explanations prevented a more cogent execution of the thesis.

'The key to effective leadership is to give the majority what they want.' Do you agree?

STEP 2: Analyse the Question Requirements (QTK)

Q => Do you agree = agreement entails a qualified extent (e.g. to a very large extent) in order to show greater evaluation

T => The importance of popular opinion in determining effective leadership

K => Key = instrumental, the answer to, the essence, the main factor

Effective = denotes an understanding of effective leadership, able to produce desired results, means versus ends, etc.

Majority = the other side of the dichotomy i.e. followers, making up most of the population, assumed to be led and governed rather than leading themselves

What they want = wants and needs of people are varied, competing and unending, some reference to Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs and general economic theories and concepts, wants could be denoted as popular demands of the people (i.e. populism)

STEP 3: Brainstorm for Relevant Content (5 brainstorming techniques)

PRESM/6 Players/IFCNG:

Social/Political

- In democracies, political leaders are accountable to the people who have voted them into office, so giving them what they want in terms of the desired mode of governance is largely reasonable
- What people want may not be what they *actually* need – effective leadership entails having the acumen to discern and balance the two
- Minority rights are also of concern – political leaders in power should not of course, pander to the wants of the majority and totally neglect or remain indifferent to the wants of the minority – this goes against the ethos of effective governance
- As populism rears its head globally, effective leadership requires firm statesmanship to know when it is permissible and when it is not to give in

Economic/Social

- Even though it may be a utopic vision to give people whatever they want, it is a reality that there are limited economic resources in any country, and the onus is upon the government to distribute and allocate resources equitably across society
- Giving whatever the majority want is essentially like a parent giving a child whatever the child wants – an act of spoiling. People should also learn that nothing comes for free and everything comes with certain amount of effort, contribution and even sacrifice (e.g. concepts of meritocracy and opportunity costs)

STEP 4: Decide on Thesis

THESIS: I do not agree that the key to effective leadership is to give the majority what they want.

STEP 5: Organise Content

Qualified Thesis: Largely No

Intro + Thesis (GIST)

G: "Make America great again" was United States President Donald Trump's campaign slogan in the recent U.S. elections. It was a populist decision to garner support from the majority of US voters and this worked as Trump came into power.

I: The key to good governance is making decisions for the good of the people. It may not be what the people want, but it is necessary for social welfare.

I/S: Many say that as leadership is elected on the basis of democracy and is through popular votes, effective leadership is to give the majority what they want, for it is the majority who elected leaders into power to make decisions on their behalf.

T: As such, I do not agree that the key to effective leadership is to give the majority what they want.

Thesis

** GIST may not necessary be written in sequence, as can be seen in this introduction (refer to the full essay), the 'I' comes immediately before the overall thesis and stand.*

Supporting BP1: Reason for Yes & No (Antithesis + Rebuttal) + Evidence

P (Antithesis): Many argue that populist decisions ensure stability in a country, and effective leadership is to ensure peace and order in the country.

P (Rebuttal): However... effective leadership is not as simple as giving the majority what they want. Populist decisions can have devastating consequences for the people...

L (Affirmation of Thesis): As such, the notion that populist decisions would ensure stability is too simplistic a view and the key to effective leadership is not as easy as giving the majority what they want.

Your Arguments

(State when it is YES & NO)

Supporting BP2: Reason for No + Evidence

P (T.S.): The key to effective leadership is to ensure social welfare and as such, a government must achieve social inclusiveness.

L (concluding sentence): As mentioned in the above examples, effective leadership is taking into account both the majority and the minority in order to achieve social inclusiveness, which is for the welfare of the people in a country.

Supporting BP3: Reason for No + Evidence

P (T.S.): Furthermore, only the top leadership is privy to certain information and it is their responsibility to make decisions from a holistic viewpoint, and not simply giving the majority what they want, in order to ensure the development of a country.

L (concluding sentence): Good governance is to make decisions for the good of the people and to have the foresight to what is necessary and not just give the majority what they want.

Supporting BP4: Reason for No + Evidence

P (T.S.): Additionally, a government cannot simply give the majority what they want for it is hard to even determine what the majority wants.

L (concluding sentence): As such, the key to effective leadership is far more complex than giving the majority what they want.

Conclusion: Considering these situations, I maintain largely No.

In conclusion, the key to effective leadership cannot simply be giving the majority what they want. A good government would be making decisions for the good of the people and ensuring that everyone benefits, rather than just caving in to popular demand. The process of determining effective leadership is far more complex, and cannot be myopically compressed as just making populist decisions. It is only when a country thrives can a leadership be deemed as effective.

Reiterate Thesis

** Notice how the writer nuances the concluding thoughts with discourse markers and qualifying phrases (underlined words) to show evaluation*

Laura Au 16A03

‘The key to effective leadership is to give the majority what they want.’ Do you agree?

“Make America great again” was United States President Donald Trump’s campaign slogan in the recent U.S. elections. It was a populist decision to garner support from the majority of US voters and this worked as Trump came into power. However, whether this leadership is effective remains in question. Many say that as leadership is elected on the basis of democracy and is through popular votes, effective leadership is to give the majority what they want, for it is the majority who elected leaders into power to make decisions on their behalf. While this being said, the key to good governance is making decisions for the good of the people. It may not be what the people want, but it is necessary for social welfare. As such, I do not agree that the key to effective leadership is to give the majority what they want.

Many argue that populist decisions ensure stability in a country, and effective leadership is to ensure peace and order in the country. In the 2011 Jasmine Revolution and the subsequent Arab Spring, calls for greater democracy in the Middle Eastern states had led to widespread bloodshed as governments clamped down on dissidents with brutal force. Political turmoil in Egypt and Libya resulted in chaos and disorder as the majority fought for what they wanted. Therein lies the belief that in order to ensure stability in a country, governments must listen to the people and make populist decisions. However, in the ongoing civil war in Syria between the majority who seek to topple the dictator Bashar Assad’s regime and establish an Islamic State and Assad’s government, effective leadership is not as simple as giving the majority what they want. Populist decisions can have devastating consequences for the people, and this would be evident should Assad cease fighting against the majority. Terrorism would take root and the supposed peace and order that would follow may not happen, as other external powers like the U.S. would intervene further in order to stop it. As such, the notion that populist decisions would ensure stability is too simplistic a view and the key to effective leadership is not as easy as giving the majority what they want.

The key to effective leadership is to ensure social welfare and as such, a government must achieve social inclusiveness. Societal welfare is to ensure that both the majority and the minority are included in the country. This is evident when former Australian Prime Minister Kevin Rudd acknowledged that the Constitution did not adequately address the issues of recognition of Indigenous Australians and their legal and constitutional protection and steps

Absolute

✓ An engaging and relevant start to the introduction.

✓ Clear distinctions made between what is mere leadership and effective leadership.

✓ Criteria for effective leadership stated so as to justify why it is not just about giving the majority what they want.

✓ Clear example given with good evaluation.

needed to be taken to ensure that they are formally recognised as part of Australia. While this decision was not in line with what the majority wanted, it was an important step in creating social inclusiveness and including the minority Aboriginals. Furthermore, the minority in society can be easily overlooked and it is up to a government to include them in the country. This has resulted in the reserved elections for a Malay President in Singapore in order to allow for fair representation. While this decision, too, was not a popular one and was met with criticism, it is a symbolic step forward in the inclusion of minorities. As mentioned in the above examples, effective leadership is taking into account both the majority and the minority in order to achieve social inclusiveness, which is for the welfare of the people in a country.

An abrupt end to this body paragraph. Clearer links need to be made to the key words in the question.

Furthermore, only the top leadership is privy to certain information and it is their responsibility to make decisions from a holistic viewpoint, and not simply giving the majority what they want, in order to ensure the development of a country. As the government has access to certain economic information, it is their duty to ensure the sustained growth of the country regardless of whether the majority want it or not. The European credit crisis occurred because the government of Portugal and Spain refused to make unpopular decisions despite it being for the good of the country. The government refused to cut down government spending on healthcare and unemployment benefits which was what the majority wanted, and this resulted in ballooning government debts and ultimately led to bankruptcy. In addition, the debt crisis in Greece that has resulted in widespread unemployment occurred because the government gave in to popular sentiments and refused to take austerity measures imposed by the International Monetary Fund as part of the conditions for a bail out. Evidently, effective leadership cannot only make popular decisions, but also has to push the boundaries and make unpopular, painful decisions for the good of the people. Good governance is to make decisions for the good of the people and to have the foresight to what is necessary and not just give the majority what they want.

Point made at the start needs to be more concise and less convoluted so that the argument can be clearly expressed.

✓ Clear example with elaboration given.

✓ A clear link that sums up the whole BP

Additionally, a government cannot simply give the majority what they want for it is hard to even determine what the majority wants. It is an uphill task to take into account the opinions of the vast majority and can only result in bitter divisions should the government choose to take one side but not the other. As such, the key to effective leadership is far more complex than giving the majority what they want.

This body paragraph appears to be written in a haste and is rather skimpy. Further development of ideas and examples needed.

In conclusion, the key to effective leadership cannot simply be giving the majority what they want. A good government would be making decisions for the good of the people and ensuring that everyone benefits, rather than just caving in to popular demand. The process of determining effective leadership is far more complex, and cannot be myopically compressed as just making populist decisions. It is only when a country thrives can a leadership be deemed as effective. GRADE: A	✓ Overall a cohesive essay with a consistent thesis. Good insight provided.
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Learning Points:



Essay is largely well argued and substantiated. Balance is well managed with insightful and engaging arguments. Effective use of language throughout.



Better time management needed to ensure that each body paragraph is adequately developed and the conclusion is as impactful as the introduction.

Teng Wei Han 16S16**Can terrorism ever be eradicated?**

The modern world that we live in today is often described as volatile, uncertain, complex and in many regions, dangerous. However, it is not as precarious as compared to decades ago. In the past, without globalisation and the Internet, the complexity of world issues could be suppressed and managed. However, as time progressed, the individual and globalisation have caused an amplified change in this world. One of the reasons why the modern world is more often than not dubbed dangerous and uncertain is due to increasing threats brought about by terrorism. Terrorism, which is to incite hatred and create conflicts against others of different political agenda is not so much a new concept. In fact, it has been prominent since the 1900s. However, with the effects of globalisation, the impact is scaled to levels so huge that it may never be eradicated.

With increased media proliferation and technological advancements in the modern world, the impact that comes about from the uncontrolled spread of political agenda and ideology through media platforms continue to make terrorism hard to eradicate. In the past, political ideology was easily spread even without the internet, through other forms of media such as newspapers, books, radio to name a few. These platforms allowed a variety of political ideologies to be spread and at huge volumes as well. Take for instance Rwanda, which experienced a massive genocide in the 1990s. Geographically, Rwanda is a landlocked country surrounded by larger African neighbours but is a country with mountainous terrain. Much of the population that is made up of Tutsis and Hutus were illiterate but due to the radio as a source of media, it allowed for the spread of hate speech by the Hutus against the Tutsis which was in part the cause of the conflict. In the modern world, globalisation has taken root and this has allowed the actions and ideology of individuals to be amplified. Media proliferation and infiltration in our lives has allowed information to be spread at greater volumes and within shorter periods of time. This has allowed terrorist groups such as ISIS to make use of this to their advantage by making use of platforms such as Facebook, Telegram and WhatsApp to recruit fighters across the world or to spread their ideology and have fighters incite hate and terror in their own backyard. This has therefore made it virtually impossible to eradicate online terrorism.

Terrorism cannot be eradicated due to the corruption of political figureheads in other countries. Their actions have therefore allowed terrorist groups to obtain sustainable sources of support to remain relevant. Previously, terrorist groups such as Al-Qaeda

Absolute

✓ Relevant characteristics and challenges of today's world that transits nicely to the issue of terrorism.

Stand should be aligned to the polarity of the question – 'can'.

✓ Clear argument raised.

Illustration needs to be more cogent. Unnecessary details given about the Rwandan genocide that are not central to the point raised at the start of the body paragraph.

were able to remain afloat due to the fact that they were being bankrolled by states in the Middle East. Terrorist organisations such as Al-Qaeda for instance were able to continue to maintain their operations as they had control over oil reserves which allowed them to gain sources of revenue. This allowed them to maintain operations and terrorise more people. The modern world, despite being dubbed more liberal and democratic, still faces terrorism-related problems as states continue to fund terrorist groups for reasons due to corruption or seeking relevance. In the case of Qatar, though it was clearly not trying to seek relevance, being a country full of oil reserves and earns high revenues due to selling of crude oil, it is still rich. However, the recent announcement by countries such as Saudi Arabia to cut ties with them had raised questions as to why this has happened. Reasons cited include Qatar supporting the Muslim Brotherhood as well as ISIS. This later led to critics questioning the 'cleanliness' of the government. Therefore, terrorism cannot be eradicated as terrorist groups are still supported by states that keep them alive.

Many reasons why terrorism arose is due to the fact that social segregation occurs in various parts of the world. In the past, when technology was not as advanced as it is now, modes of transport to different countries was quite restricted, but still saw immigrants from the Middle East migrate to countries in Europe. However, governments in European countries such as Britain, France and Belgium to name a few did little to integrate these immigrants into their societies. In light of recent attacks in Paris and London, it has been revealed that many areas in Britain and Belgium saw the emergence of once unknown enclaves. Due to racial discrimination by the citizens of these countries, it resulted in many of these immigrants to be socially segregated and abused in these communities. This has resulted in many of them turning to extremist groups and thereby picking up their ideologies. With the humanitarian crisis the world is facing now where there is massive outflows of immigrants and governments of countries such as Britain and the United States shutting their borders and stopping these immigrants from entering their countries, more hatred and discrimination would be incited. Without any responsibility taken up by governments, more of such enclaves are going to sprawl and when this is not controlled, more problems would almost certainly arise, and thereby making terrorism impossible to eradicate.

Despite all the doom and gloom surrounding terrorism, it may still be possible to eradicate it despite the mess we are undergoing. This is due to the fact that the resolve of the government and its people could see more people being educated about the spread of wrongful extremist ideology. This though, would require great

Student relied on a narration of one specific example to justify point made again.

Body paragraph contains an evaluative argument but needs to be more succinct.

Point made at the start of the body paragraph should link more clearly to the issue of why terrorism is impossible to eradicate, rather than phrasing it as a reason for the rise of terrorism in the world today.

✓ Apt vocabulary used.

✓ There is attempt to provide balance and show that the situation may not be as dire as it seems.

responsibility by the government. More often than not, conflict occurs due to a combination of these factors, namely resources, healthcare and infrastructure as well as identity. Many countries in the past faced problems with regard to a lack of resources and infrastructure. As such, conflicts arose as people fought for their own survival. To put a case in point, in Pakistan, the Taleban managed to gain a foothold in the country due to the fact that many of the Pakistani people were mired in poverty and the country lacks amenities and proper systems for them. As such, many children were persuaded by the Taleban to its sex industry where they would be paid. Parents would willingly let them go as they had no other options as well. This led to not only the emergence of a sexual slavery industry but also the spread of terrorism by the Taleban through kidnappings and murders. Schools themselves were resented and often a place of target for terrorist acts by the Taleban. However, in recent years, the Pakistani government has increase enforcement and security in the country, on one front trying to drive out militants and attitudes of the children, it reduces their chances of children giving in and to join militant groups but at the same time allowing them to climb up the social ladder and being able to earn more stable income. Therefore, terrorism could be eradicated if we nip the problem in the bud through methods such as education.

With the continued occurrence of terrorism in the world in recent times, it does not seem like the spread of terrorism would halt and eradicated in the first place. With more countries being isolationist and less willing to help in humanitarian crisis that the world is facing, the problem is certainly perpetuated and undoubtedly bleak. In order for terrorism not to take root, strong political will is needed by the government and the people to stand up against terrorism to prevent it from dividing and tearing their social fabric. One of the possible solutions being education may be able to nip the problem of terrorism in the bud but in practice, this may be hard to achieve. Hence, terrorism may never be eradicated.

GRADE: A

✓ Student continues to acknowledge the difficulties that we might face when trying to eradicate terrorism even though efforts are being made.

✓ Student offers insights and resolution. The tone of the conclusion and choice of words used are in line with the overall stand made in the introduction.

Learning Points:



Essay shows that the student has good content knowledge in the topic area. It is largely well argued and substantiated. Effective use of language throughout.



Unnecessary details should have been avoided. Cogency is important and that affects language scores. Points should consistently be focused on answering the crux of the question.

How far can a culturally diverse society build unity?

STEP 2: Analyse the Question Requirements (QTK)

Q => How far = to a large or small extent

T => Are peace and harmony possible amid differences?

K => Can = the focus, rather than 'should', although an adept essay would be able to handle both 'can' and 'should' to increase the persuasiveness of the arguments

Build = focus is on the *process* of achieving unity, even though unity is the *goal*

Unity = cohesion and perhaps a common identity or sense of belonging to one another (inferred), assumption is the possibility of retaining unity in diversity, an essentially paradoxical position

STEP 3: Brainstorm for Relevant Content (5 brainstorming techniques)

Social/P**olitical/**P**sychological**

- Many cultures ingrain the young about individual cultural identity through differentiation with 'other' cultures (e.g. negative stereotypes), causing bias and prejudice to be deep-seated; this might present a hurdle to building true unity in the long-run
- People tend to rely on pre-conceived ideas and stereotypes as heuristics to 'size-up' people of other cultures that they do not know well or have little contact with
- With globalisation and the dilution of ethnic cultures in general, some groups of people may become less sensitive or tolerant as to why certain groups of people still hold on to particular cultural identities (and vice-versa), thus intensifying cultural polarisation (e.g. Western liberal culture versus more conservative cultures of the Middle East)

Ethical/M**oral/**E**ducation**

- As cultures continue to be varied today, the key to unity and harmony is by focusing on moral values that are common to most predominant cultures (e.g. the Golden Rule) that may be expressed differently, through various levels of society and via different stakeholders

Economic/P**olitical/**S**ocial**

- A common goal such as national identity and greater economic prosperity for society at large, spearheaded by the government can help to ameliorate cultural differences, helping the entire society level up to greater heights in standards and quality of living that leads to a virtuous cycle
- Conversely, the government needs to ensure that certain cultural minorities are not sidelined economically or socially in the march towards greater economic progress, as this could serve to greater polarise different cultural milieus

STEP 4: Decide on Thesis

THESIS: Considering the tense relationship between certain ethnic groups today, due to the rise of extremist groups and stereotypes perpetuated by the media, I disagree to a large extent that a culturally diverse society can build unity.

STEP 5: Organise Content

Qualified Thesis: Largely No

Intro + Thesis (GIST)

G/S: At the surface level, a more diverse social fabric may be seen as a colourful masterpiece, but is it actually just a pretty façade for chaos and discord?

I/S: Some may believe that having different racial and religious backgrounds will lead to a healthy development of a community, where a wholesome identity can be cultivated from each unique culture. However, there are others who scoff at this idealistic belief and instead view societies with an abundance of different cultures as unstable; a breeding ground for conflicts.

T: Considering the tense relationship between certain ethnic groups today, due to the rise of extremist groups and stereotypes perpetuated by the media, I disagree to a large extent that a culturally diverse society can build unity.

Thesis

G/S: *Writer hooks the reader directly with a challenge via a rhetorical question, introducing the sides and exposing the tension within the topic as well*

I/S: *Notice how the writer is able to deftly weave the 'I' into the 'S' rather seamlessly, thus achieving economy as well as effectiveness at the same time*

T: *A heavily qualified thesis, which shows some degree of painstaking evaluation*

Supporting BP1: Reason for No + Evidence

P (T.S.): A major hindrance to the development of strong bonds within culturally varied communities is the lack of meaningful understanding directed towards the importance and identity of other ethnic groups.

L (concluding sentence): Thus, superficial relationships which are of short-term significance have brought about a lack of appreciation for the value of other ethnicities in a racially diverse society.

Your Arguments (State when it is NO)

Supporting BP2: Reason for No + Evidence

P (T.S.): When left unchecked, this could even escalate to having social ties corrupted by bigoted and negative stereotypes in culturally diverse communities.

L (concluding sentence): Thus, xenophobia and narrow mind-sets within ethnically diverse societies causes social division.

Supporting BP3: Reason for No + Evidence

P (T.S.): This social distancing is made worse within countries with numerous racial and religious backgrounds when negativity towards these other groups are cultivated by the authorities themselves.

L (concluding sentence): Thus, social conflict is further entrenched within culturally diverse countries when recognised authorities show support for such mind-sets.

Supporting BP4: Reason for Yes + Evidence

P (T.S.): However, there have been instances where racially and religiously diverse countries have proven that, when managed properly, measures can be put in place which builds a welcoming and open environment for all cultures to bond.

L (concluding sentence): Thus, when proper strategies are implemented which benefit all ethnic groups, social cohesion can be promoted.

Your Arguments (State when it is YES)

Supporting BP5: Reason for Yes + Evidence

P (T.S.): Furthermore, in the long-run, this social cohesion can add to and enhance the collective social identity.

L (concluding sentence): Thus, social unity can be built within culturally diverse societies with the construction of a more encompassing identity.

Conclusion: Considering these situations, I maintain largely No.

In conclusion, I believe to a large extent that a culturally diverse society more often than not fails to build unity. This is because despite the possibilities of having proper measures in place to promote social cohesion, current racial and religious tensions are far more persistent and proliferate. However, globalisation may eventually result in more open hearts.

**Again, note the use of the discourse marker 'despite' to emphasise that the writer has considered alternative viewpoints extensively before deriving the conclusion*

How far can a culturally diverse society build unity?

At the surface level, a more diverse social fabric may be seen as a colourful masterpiece, but is it actually just a pretty façade for chaos and discord? Some may believe that having different racial and religious backgrounds will lead to a healthy development of a community, where a wholesome identity can be cultivated from each unique culture. However, there are others who scoff at this idealistic belief and instead view societies with an abundance of different cultures as unstable; a breeding ground for conflicts. Considering the tense relationship between certain ethnic groups today, due to the rise of extremist groups and stereotypes perpetuated by the media, I disagree to a large extent that a culturally diverse society can build unity.

A major hindrance to the development of strong bonds within culturally varied communities is the lack of meaningful understanding directed towards the importance and identity of other ethnic groups. In order to build lasting and positive relationships with others, their value must first be appreciated and given due respect. However, a lack of knowledge in terms of what other races and groups can contribute to society prevents them from being given due credit and individual ethnic groups simply do not see the worth of embracing other groups. For example, Malaysia and China are among the countries which have numerous ethnicities within the population yet also have a large number of prominent and institutionalised schools which cater to a specific race or religion without exposing students to other cultures. This has developed generation after generation of students who will carry on narrow worldviews into their adult life, where they are only aware of their own background and not the beauty of other cultures. Unfortunately, even when there is effort made to educate the population on the other races, such as having an annual Racial Harmony Day in Singapore, it is not sufficient. This is because the top-down approach generally causes people to think about racial harmony as a single event that is often forgotten afterwards. Furthermore, wearing cultural costumes of other races does not actually embrace knowledge of other races if it simply stops at donning the outfit. Thus, superficial relationships which are of short-term significance have brought about a lack of appreciation for the value of other ethnicities in a racially diverse society.

When left unchecked, this could even escalate to having social ties corrupted by bigoted and negative stereotypes in culturally diverse communities. Due to a lack of appreciation for other ethnic groups, as mentioned earlier, flippant and even hostile comments may emerge due to ignorance or warped perceptions of these other groups. For example, in Singapore, Amy Cheong received a stern warning from the police due to her insulting remarks against Malay weddings held at the void decks. Such instances are not isolated even though they are dealt with by the law and this makes certain racial and religious groups feel unwelcomed and targeted, promoting tension. This is clearly seen in the United States of America (USA) where numerous racial enclaves for various

Simple polarity

✓ Shows awareness of both sides of the argument

✓ Clear justifications for stand

✓ Stand elucidated by insightful evaluation

✓ Addresses entrenched social structures that are difficult to change

✓ Develops and strengthens the point further by highlighting ineffective solutions.

✓ Point is well-linked to previous BP via cause and effect.

✓ Two examples from two different contexts showing different ways social discord can manifest. This

immigrant groups such as Mexicans, Chinese and Indian nationalities exist. From this, prejudices can be seen as a force which causes social segregation and misunderstandings. Thus, xenophobia and narrow mind-sets within ethnically diverse societies causes social division. This social distancing is made worse within countries with numerous racial and religious backgrounds when negativity towards these other groups are <u>cultivated by the authorities themselves</u>. By having the weight of these recognised and influential authorities behind culturally biased opinions, it gives skewed mind-sets legitimacy and power to further reject other racial and religious groups. For example, when France passed a legislation banning the donning of a hijab, anti-Muslim sentiments became more prominent within the country and French Muslims felt rejected from their own community. This rejection is also seen today with President Donald Trump's immigration ban in place in the USA which prevents majority Muslim immigrants from entering the country. This officially enforced practices further institutionalises social stigma against other races and religions, especially in places where those other races and religions are part of a minority group and are less able to defend themselves against such injustice. Thus, social conflict is further entrenched within culturally diverse countries when recognised authorities show support for such mind-sets. However, there have been instances where racially and religiously diverse countries have proven that, <u>when managed properly</u>, measures can be put in place which builds a welcoming and open environment for all cultures to bond. <u>When the needs of the different races and religions are taken into consideration when developing policies for the collective society</u>, it promoted inclusive happiness and progress which is necessary for social bonding. For example, Singapore makes it mandatory for all students to learn both English Language and their Mother Tongue Language. Through this, those educated in Singapore are able to stay rooted to their individual culture while also being able to interact and communicate with other races via a common language. This also ensures that all races will have the advantage of speaking English when they enter the workforce, preventing exclusion based on communication difficulties. Thus, when proper strategies are implemented which benefit all ethnic groups, social cohesion can be promoted. <u>Furthermore, in the long-run</u>, this social cohesion can add to and enhance the collective social identity. When all the different races and religions work together within a community, the unique aspects of each group has the ability to shape the development of the nation's identity. This representation and collective effort cultivates national pride and makes the nation unique from others. For example, Singapore's 'rojak' culture has brought about the unique 'Singlish' dialect which comprises terms from numerous local dialects. This has become a defining factor for Singapore as a collective entity. Thus, social unity can be built within culturally diverse societies with the construction of a more encompassing identity.	emphasises that the problem is not exclusive to only particular societies. ✓ Highlights the role of a different player in society, besides individuals themselves. ✓ Student highlights an exception, but states clear conditions for its validity. Each BP should aim to have 2 examples to score higher. ✓ Good use of connector and LT vs. ST evaluative perspective Limited examples provided, and insufficient elaboration/link back to HOW Singlish has unified the Singaporean identity.
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In conclusion, I believe to a large extent that a culturally diverse society more often than not fails to build unity. This is because despite the possibilities of having proper measures in place to promote social cohesion, current racial and religious tensions are far more persistent and proliferate. However, globalisation may eventually result in more open hearts.

✓Use of the modal 'may' is effective in emphasising how unity is a possibility, but not a certainty, unless conditions are met.

How does 'globalisation' link to inclusive policies and a collective identity?
Closing line is vague

Grade: A

Learning Points:



Overall, a comprehensive and well-balanced essay. Effective use of language.



Student could have been more consistent in providing two examples per BP, and clearer concluding line.

Lee Jiayi 16A03

In today's world, has ethics taken a backseat where food is concerned?

Living in this highly pragmatic society, where focus is placed heavily on money making, the lines between being ethical and unethical are sometimes blurred. In the context of where food is concerned, the issue of ethics is analysed in the aspect of how food is prepared – whether it contains harmful ingredients and how livestock is treated with a rise in food safety scandals as well as an increase in reports of livestock being reared in unsanitary conditions to reduce costs of production and maximise profits, it can be said that ethics has taken a backseat where food is concerned. Producers of food have now only one focus – profit maximising, even if it is at the expense of food safety and well-being of livestock. This has led to a series of problems, even requiring government intervention as producers prove to be incapable of being ethical in food production. Thus, this shows that there has been a loss and erosion of ethics where food is concerned.

Being ethical is no longer a priority where food is concerned as producers are more interested in making profits when greed and selfishness override basic values and principles, and we see producers engaging in unethical means just for the sake of profits. This mentality is evidenced by an increase in food safety scandals in recent years. The Sanlu milk powder incident in 2008 is a clear example of how ethics have taken a backseat where food is concerned. Producers of milk powder in China included a harmful ingredient, melamine, so as to decrease their costs of production and gain more profits. The result was the deaths of many babies and toddlers due to liver failure after consuming the milk. In another example closer to home, Ikea was accused of using horsemeat in their meatballs. This created a stir in the Singaporean society where the ethics of food producers was questioned. While this scandal proved to be untrue, it raises the question of how producers nowadays are not trustworthy or reliable, and are capable of causing harm to millions of innocent people for the sake of making profits. Thus, such incidents clearly show that where food is concerned, producers may lie about ingredients and may even go to the extent of using uncertified ingredients in their food products. All these show that ethics has truly taken a backseat in the food scene.

Being ethical has proven to be an eroding principle as food producers subject livestock to abuse and torture in the process of food preparation. Based on reports in recent years, we see many neglecting animal rights and breeding livestock in unsanitary conditions. Despite laws stipulating how livestock should be handled or prepared, these producers choose to overlook such issues so as to save costs. An example would be how cows were found to be reared in small cages with unsanitary conditions. These cows are reared without much exercise and are hence more susceptible to diseases. What is worse is that because of such unethical ways of preparing food, it has led to the spread of animal

Simple Polarity

✓ Student shows awareness of today's context.

✓ While explanations are slightly repetitive, student is clear in stating her stand and her justifications for it.

✓ Clear point + reason

✓ Student makes the effort to explain how the examples support her stand, rather than simply leaving the reader to make the link.

Example lacks specific info like country, company, year of incident etc. Hence, example lacks credibility.

to human diseases. These producers have no care for such issues and continue their unethical ways because it is more cost efficient. Another example would be how dead pigs were thrown and disposed into the Yellow River in China for convenience. This lack of ethics led to water contamination and people falling ill. Therefore, since producers of food have no care for livestock and other unintended consequences and are more concerned about their profits, it can be said that ethics has taken a backseat where food is concerned.

However, some may argue that ethics is still a priority as we see a rise in government regulations and enforcement of stricter food laws across the world. There has been an increase in efforts to ensure the safety of food. For example, China has stepped up policies such as the food safety law in 2006 which was recently revised to better address the issue of food safety. In Singapore, the government set up the Agri-Food & Veterinary Authority of Singapore (AVA) to ensure that all food factories and farms in the country are subjected to strict requirements to ensure that food is handled properly. Furthermore, the AVA looks through all food products coming into Singapore to ensure that they meet basic standards and are safe for consumption. However, the fact that there is even a need for such regulations put in place shows that producers are becoming more unethical in the preparations of food and need to be closely monitored for them to do the right thing. This increase in government regulations therefore shows that there is indeed a lack of ethics where food is concerned and required intervention and strict monitoring to make sure producers are not unethical in their food dealings.

Proponents of this argument may also highlight that news reports of producers flouting food safety laws and neglecting animal rights by subjecting them to torture and abuse are not representative of all producers. Indeed, the majority of food producers are ethical in their production and do not violate laws. An example would be how coffee giant Starbucks only buys ethical coffee beans which means that these coffee beans do not come from places where workers are denied human rights. However, it must be noted that many of such 'ethical' companies, Starbucks included, were pressured into being ethical. A few months before Starbucks announced its 'ethical coffee beans', it was the subject of much public backlash where it was discovered that it purchased coffee beans from where workers were not given proper working conditions. Thus, this shows that ethics is not a concern in the context of food and firms that adhere to ethics are often pressured by public discontent or forced due to laws in place.

In conclusion, ethics has truly taken a backseat where food is concerned as producers are overly obsessed with profit maximising. Without government intervention and pressure from public, it is highly unlikely that food producers would adhere to ethical moral values in food production and preparation. More needs to be done to ensure producers are ethical as this leads to a rise of problems that may endanger the lives of consumers.

Grade: A

✓ Counter-argument: acknowledges other perspectives.

✓ Rebuttal shows evaluative insight – Regulation undermines virtue.

Avoid vague references

✓ Counter-argument: acknowledges another perspective.

✓ Rebuttal shows evaluative insight – an interrogation of why Starbucks appears to be ethical.

Conclusion could have been more diligent in summing up the main points of BPs 1-3.

✓ BPs are coherent with and aligned to overall thesis of essay

Learning Points:



Overall, a comprehensive and well-balanced essay. Effective use of language.



Examples could have been more specific and credible. Balance could have been clearly reflected in the introductory and conclusion paragraphs to show an overall cohesiveness of the essay.

Liu Jun Lin Aaron 16S03

Is there really a need to fear technology?

In our modern world, technology is advancing rapidly, almost exponentially, as some people would say. There is also a rise in something more concerning - the fear of technology. Technology has often been looked at as a good thing – faster productivity, efficient use of resources, expanding our scope of research, benefiting humankind as a whole. There are some, however, who recognise the downfalls of it and have even accumulated an almost instinctive fear of it. I would not blame them as there are indeed reasons to fear modern technology.

Due to technology, two areas of our lives have been compromised - our privacy and security. Technology has been advancing so much that it brings about greater communication and interconnectedness between people who are far apart, and while this does allow us to contact our loved ones, it also puts our privacy at a greater risk of being compromised. Any hacker who is skilled enough can obtain personal data anywhere from the Internet or other electronic devices, stealing valuable information from anyone. Such examples include the consistent hackings of the Pentagon to obtain military information and even the incident National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA) faced where a hacker, comfortably sitting at home, stole all of its data and even left a message for NASA stating, “your security sucks”. If a hacker can do all of that, how easily would it be to wiretap into our desktops, laptops or mobile smartphones. I would be extremely horrified if a stranger were to know everything about me. However, there are some people who argue security measures are also increasingly developed hence there is not much to worry about. But, as a matter of fact, hackings can still occur no matter how secure it is thus there is a need to be vigilant and fearful of technology.

Another considerable factor that brings about a need to fear technology is that our safety and our lives are at stake. As technology advances, many different sectors improve and one part of it that also has advanced is the production of nuclear weapons. Nuclear warfare has been around since the 1900s and now, the situation is not improving especially when there are more than ten thousand nuclear warheads capable of bringing mass destruction to planet Earth. This concerns our lives as we would not want to be decimated by these weapons. Fearing for our very own lives should be enough to reason out how dangerous technology can be. One major case is Russia's nuclear warfare programme, Russia's Dead Hand. It consists of thousands of nuclear warheads that launch when the United States (US) or North Korea decide to play a game of nuclear weaponry. It would unleash the whole Russian nuclear arsenal even if no one were alive to activate it. It is a system capable of detecting unusual nuclear activity and self-activating. It also includes the 'Tsar Bomba', only 16000 times more powerful than the combined powers of 'Little Boy' and 'Fat Man', the bombs dropped on Hiroshima and Nagasaki during World War 2. This potential to completely annihilate all of humanity provokes an

Doubt

✓ Acknowledges general positive perception of technology, but reinforces and expounds on the doubt implied in the question.

✓ Evaluation is shown in acknowledgment of common perception, and questioning its validity.

✓ Student attempts to emphasise the imperative of the concern, addressing 'really'.

Rebuttal of counter-argument could have been further developed and substantiated with evidence.

✓ Shows awareness of international relations and tensions

✓ The degree of impact of nuclear warfare effectively emphasises the imperative

unstoppable fear of losing our lives any moment, thus the need to fear technology is easily justifiable. One final aspect of grave concern is the need to fear artificial intelligence. Driverless cars and robots that make decisions based on stimuli are worrying technologies which are highly researched on in today's research and development industries. There are doubts raised such as how a car should behave if caught between risking a life and saving others. Uber and Google are companies that are focused on solving these ethical dilemmas. When such technology is accessible to public use, this raises a fear of one's safety determined by these robots and machines. We would this live in constant fear of being a victim of cold and unfeeling robotic calculations. Even if they perfect these decisions, how sure are they that the machines do not malfunction or that the software installed do not have bugs caused by particles from space that can alter the binary code. These issues have indeed raised concerns and there is a need for us to be on our guard as we do not know if artificial intelligence can be flexible in making decisions when the need arises. Hence, there is a need to fear technology. However, some suggest that robots, unlike humans, are more reliable than humans since they are able to perform calculations faster, improve productivity and do not get tired the way humans do thus we need not worry about them. But in my case, I would still be concerned over technology. Despite the need for fear and how worrying it may be, there are arguments that there is no need to fear technology. As long as we manage technology and its weaknesses well enough, there really is no need for fear since we always fear what we do not know. In that case, we should be keeping up with technology, understand how it works so that we end up controlling it, instead of it controlling us. Being slaves to fear is not healthy either, it is just like anxiety. One would not carry an open umbrella in the sun in the fear that a storm might come. Sometimes it is indeed better to just push our fears aside as there are things which we cannot control. It would be useless to worry if our planet might be hit by an asteroid, since it could happen and it is completely beyond our control. Thus fear, an emotion which helps us to see danger should also be controlled. Despite the unhealthy effects or life-threatening issues that technology may pose, it is unnecessary for us to be overly fearful. In conclusion, yes there is a need to fear technology but not excessively. Fear is not a bad thing and is a typical human emotion that helps us make judgements on and forecast certain things. A balance of it can be extremely useful for us to pre-empt danger. An excessive amount of anything is bad for anyone, fear included. We still need to be on our toes as to what risks technology may bring and stand up for our rights or opinions when we see an issue on technology so that we as humanity will be able to manage it well and make the world a better place. Grade: A	of the concern, addressing 'really'. Student should have given a reason for her insistence on her stand despite the perceived advantages of technology. This will strengthen her conclusive stance. ✓A very sensible and well-moderated position to take on the issue. This reflects a high level of maturity and insight of the student. Personal voice is strong, but conclusion lacks an overview of points as discussed in the BPs.
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Learning Points:



Overall, a comprehensive and well-balanced essay. Effective use of language.



Rebuttal should have been explained and supported to maintain overall cogency of the thesis. Concluding paragraph could have been more effective in summing up the key points discussed in the essay.